incumbent powers are all very popular among their domestic audiences. Incumbent political leaders can use BRICS actions to deflect domestic criticisms directed at themselves, despite ongoing rivalries among some BRICS powers (including between China and India or China and Russia).

Proposition 5. Collaboration by China with the other BRICS in financial statecraft is most likely when China can employ the other BRICS as a cover to make its offensive foreign policy choices appear more benign to the rest of the world.[7]

China is the clearly dominant economic power within the BRICS club, and it is the only member, as of the early 2010s, with attractive outside options to carry out systemically consequential financial statecraft on its own, without relying on the rest of the BRICS members. Lacking allies, China is likely to be motivated by the amplified impact of its financial statecraft when it is supported by the other BRICS. When China's international actions are made in the name of a diverse, multilateral group, then China's motivations may be less likely to be construed by the status quo powers as self-serving or threatening. These actions also may have a much more visible impact if conducted collectively, the benefits of which outweigh the costs of slight compromises with the other BRICS.

Proposition 6. Collaboration by the other four BRICS with China in financial statecraft is more likely when they perceive defensive opportunities to bind China by enticing it to cooperate with them over time. The other BRICS simultaneously expect to gain from China's rise.

This last proposition also recognizes the capabilities imbalance between China and the other four countries (discussed in Chapter 2) and suggests that each of them either has reasons to fear China, wants something from China, or both. The other BRICS will be more likely to collaborate with China when they see a tethering effect on China through such collaboration. Of course, these weaker BRICS governments are also motivated by the amplifying effect of BRICS positions when China is on board.

In sum, the country cases that follow in this chapter suggest that the BRICS collaborate for several reasons, ranging from their positions in the global interstate balance of capabilities, to their expectations of intragroup dynamics, to their hopes for benefits vis-à-vis other countries and each leadership's domestic constituents. Some of these reasons dominate at one time, and other motivations predominate at other times. Moreover, the mix of motivations will not be constant among the five BRICS. Nonetheless,